LS1: Dealing with customers
Complaints

PART B: Cyberattacks

Situation: You are a customer service representative at SkillUpU.com, a company that offers online business-related courses, as well as in-house training courses at various locations around England.
→ You reply to a customer complaint.

1 Reading an email of complaint

SkillUpU accepts online payments for its courses and requires students to create an account with their payment details. You receive an email of complaint from a student.

From: elario.morrison@samail.ger
To: customerservice@SkillUpU.nex
Subject: **Account hacked!**

Your security is a FAIL – my account has been hacked!

I received three emails this morning saying that I booked courses last night – while I was asleep! Conveniently, they are three of your most expensive courses – a total amount of £3600!

Sure enough, I checked my credit card and there are three entries, all with today's date, with SkillUpU as the payment recipient.

How could this happen given the amazingly secure encryption SkillUpU advertises??? You know what – your security is not amazing. In fact, you've got major problems with your security!

I'm really angry about this – I demand a full refund!

You'd better fix this immediately!

Elario Morrison

A Read the email of complaint and do the following tasks.

1 Summarize the problem and how it was discovered.
2 Describe the tone of the email.
3 Do you think that this is the right way to write a complaint in this situation?

B Change the following complaints to make them more polite. Use the phrases from the language box.

1 I'm telling you loud and clear that I'm very disappointed about the security measures.
2 You'd better get back to me by the end of the day.
3 You have a big problem with your customer account security.
4 I demand that you refund the amount of these purchases in full.
5 I'm angry about wasting my time to deal with this.
6 Your security has failed – my account has been hacked!
7 I'm telling you to fix this ASAP.

Making a complaint

I'm afraid I've got a complaint (about) …
I request that …
I'm sorry to say this but …
There could be a problem with the …
Can I ask that you …
I would appreciate it if you'd …
I'm not happy about …

› *Useful phrases: Making complaints, page 157*

C **Write a more polite version of the email of complaint in exercise 1A.**

D **Discuss the differences between the polite and impolite ways of complaining.**

– Which style of complaining do you hear most often? Which do you use?
– When would you use each style?

2 Replying to a complaint

You pass the complaint on to the IT Security team at SkillUpU. In the meantime, you reply to the customer.

A **Complete the email using phrases from the language box below.**

From: customerservice@SkillUpU.nex
To: elario.morrison@amail.ger
Subject: **Re: Account hacked!**

Dear Mr Morrison

___[1] that you are experiencing difficulties with our service and ___[2] the upset this has caused you.

___[3] that your request is being taken very seriously and has been passed on to our fraud investigation team.

___[4] that we are actively investigating the matter and will contact you within 24 hours to provide an update. I request that you ___[5].

Due to the possibility that your credit card details have been compromised, we recommend that you contact your credit card provider to be advised on further actions.

___[6] to resolve this issue as soon as possible.

___[7] that this has caused you and we ___[8].

Yours sincerely

SkillUpU Customer Service

Replying to a complaint

I can assure you (that) …
I'm very sorry to hear (that) …
I would like to apologize for …
Please bear with us in the meantime.
Please be assured (that) …
We are doing everything we can (to) …
We regret any inconvenience (that) …
We thank you for your patience.

› *Useful phrases: Dealing with complaints, page 158*

B **Answer the following questions.**

– How are SkillUpU handling the complaint?
– What actions has Elario been asked to take?

TOOLBOX

to compromise sth – *(Daten) unberechtigt nutzen, gefährden*
fraud – *Betrug*
to investigate – *untersuchen*
to resolve sth – *etw klären*

3 Replying to a complaint about credit card management

The customer service team receives a further complaint about credit card management.

Write a reply to Brian Jenson and cover the following points:

– apologize for the difficulties
– you are aware that the process is confusing for many users
– provide a link to the instructions for changing an expired credit card
– advise him that you will follow up in 24 hours to check his progress
– you will ensure that the service is not disrupted
– conclude with an appropriate message

› *Useful phrases: Dealing with complaints, page 158*

From: B.Jenson@gmail.onx
To: customerservice@SkillUpU.nex
Subject: **Can't change default credit card**

Hi

I am writing to complain about the credit card management on your website – it is horribly confusing! I want to remove my expired credit card from my billing details, but I can't because it is my 'default' account in the system. I keep getting emails telling me that my service will be cut off!

You really should make it easier to manage so that these emails stop and my service continues!

Brian Jenson

4 Handling a complaint from a customer

Now it is time to handle customer complaints face-to-face.

Work with a partner and role-play an over-the-counter complaint. Swap roles when you are finished.

Partner A:
While you are out shopping at the weekend your mobile phone shuts down and won't react when you try to turn it on. You need your phone for your work and personal life, so you want it working as soon as possible. Frustrated, you go into the mobile phone store and complain to the customer service staff.
Keep your complaint as polite as possible.

Partner B:
You are part of the customer service staff in a mobile phone store. It is your job to handle customers' complaints professionally.
– Make the customer feel that you take them seriously.
– Check that they are a customer.
– Confirm that you will help them.
– Suggest that they try holding the side button on their phone for 10 seconds to reset.
– Ask them to leave their phone with you for an hour if they have time.
– Explain the process you follow if you can't fix it in an hour.

Attempt to fix in-store within hour. ▶ Send to technical support. Attempt to fix within 48 hours. ▶ Replace device.

COMMUNICATION: A telephone complaint

Situation: You work at World Medical, a company that manufactures medical equipment.
→ **You deal with a telephone complaint.**

1 Dealing with complaints on the telephone

Your supervisor gives you a list of phrases for dealing with complaints and tells you to keep it by the phone.

Match the headings (1–5) to the phrases (a–j). There are at least two phrases for every heading. Some phrases match more than one heading.

1 Apologizing
2 Asking for information
3 Reacting to information
4 Action
5 Ending the call

a Can I just check with you that I've understood everything?
b Could you tell me what it's about, please?
c Could you give me the order number, please?
d I'll have a replacement sent out as soon as possible.
e I'm sorry to hear that.
f Is there anything else I can do for you today?
g Just a moment while I write that down.
h Oh, no. That doesn't sound at all good.
i Thank you for your call. Once again, I'm sorry that there was a problem.
j We're prepared to replace the goods at our expense.

› *Useful phrases: Dealing with complaints, page 158*

2 Dealing politely with customers

A new customer, Jerzy Adamczyk, calls to complain about a trial order of X-ray machines. Your colleague, Melissa Wolf, takes the call. She is not very polite.

42 A **With a partner, listen to the phone call and decide together how you would improve it. Make a list.**

43 B **Now listen to how Melissa should have dealt with the phone call with Jerzy Adamczyk. Which (if any) of your improvements does she make?**

Making / Dealing with complaints on the phone
Give your name clearly at the start of the call and write down the name of the person you are speaking to immediately. If necessary, check the spelling of the name.

3 Complaining to a supplier

World Medical ships their orders in special containers made by Sheffield Metal, a company in England. The latest consignment has not arrived, so your supervisor phones to complain about the delay in delivery. Jeanette Hogg answers the phone.

A **Work with a partner. Look at the phrases (a–h) below and decide who says what – the caller or the person taking the call. (There are four phrases for each speaker.)**

a delivery was promised
b How can I help you?
c I will do my best
d it's an order for
e the exact details
f the order number?
g to enquire about my order
h We can't fulfil our orders

B **When you have finished, match the phrases (a–h) with the gaps (1–8) in the text to complete the transcript of the phone call.**

Jeanette Good morning. Sheffield Metal, Sales Department. Jeannette Hogg speaking.
Max Good morning. This is Max Jahn from World Medical in Germany.
Jeanette Good morning, Mr Jahn. ___[1]
Max I'm calling ___[2] for containers for medical equipment. The order was sent almost one month ago, on 18 April, and ___[3] by 3 May but, so far, nothing has arrived.
Jeanette Oh. I'm sorry to hear that. Could you give me ___[4]
Max Yes. It's DF54736.
Jeanette DF54736. Just a moment, please. I'll check. I'm sorry, Mr Jahn. I don't seem to have any record of your order. Can I just check that I've understood everything? The order number is DF54736 and you ordered the containers on 18 April. Could you give me ___[5] of the order, please?
Max Yes, ___[6] your aluminium containers for medical equipment.
Jeanette Aluminium containers for medical equipment. Mr Jahn, I'll have to speak to my colleague to find out what the problem is. Can I get back to you later?
Max Well, yes. But I hope it won't take long. ___[7] until we have your containers.
Jeanette Yes. I realize that, Mr Jahn. I'm very sorry about this and ___[8] to get back to you as soon as possible.
Max Many thanks for your help, Ms Hogg.

44 C **Now listen and check your answers.**

4 Role-play: Making a complaint by telephone

Now it is time to practise dealing with telephone complaints.

A **Work with a partner and role-play a telephone complaint using the prompts below.**

PARTNER A
You work for the supplier. You take a call from a customer who makes a complaint.
Before you begin, check your knowledge of phrases for dealing with complaints (exercise 1).

PARTNER B
You are the customer. Before you begin, make some notes as follows:
– the name of your firm
– the order number
– the date of delivery
– the problem (e.g. damaged/wrong goods, delay in delivery)
– what you hope from Partner A

› *Useful phrases: Telephoning, page 153; Making complaints, page 157; Dealing with complaints, page 158*

B **When you have finished the phone call, change roles and do it again using different details.**

DAS KANN ICH (Unit 11)
– Fortschritte im Digitalisierungsprozess in verschiedenen Ländern erkennen und vergleichen. (Foundation)
– Empfehlungen abgeben, wie man einen Prozess durch Digitalisierung verbessern kann. (Part A)
– Einen Plan vorstellen, um Verbesserungen in einer Firma durch das Internet der Dinge (IoT) einzuführen. (Part B)
– Mit telefonischen Beschwerden auf Englisch richtig umgehen. (Communication)